

DELTA An often fan-shaped area at the mouth of a river that is built up by deposited sediment.

DIURNAL Active by day.

DIVERSITY See *Biodiversity*.

DREY A squirrel's nest.

DRY FOREST A forest growing in a region that has a long dry season.

E
ECHOLOCATION A method of detecting surrounding objects and prey, used by dolphins, bats, and some other animals, that involves emitting high-pitched sounds and interpreting their echoes.

ECOREGION Any geographical region defined on the basis of the particular ecosystems and distinctive flora and fauna that it contains.

ECOSYSTEM Any community of organisms considered together with the interactions between them and their associated physical environment.

EL NIÑO Phenomenon involving the waters of the eastern Pacific off South America that become warmer than usual every few years. It is part of a larger climatic cycle that seriously affects marine life and global weather patterns.

EMERGENT (1) In tropical forests, an emergent is a tall tree that grows higher than the surrounding tree canopy. (2) In freshwater ecosystems, emergent plants, such as the bulrush, grow out of the water into the air above. See also *Canopy*.

ENDEMIC A living species native to a particular region and only found in that region.

ENDOSKELETON An internal skeleton, such as the bony skeleton of vertebrates.

EPIPHYTE A plant that grows on another plant as a means of support.

EROSION The processes by which rocks or soil are loosened and transported to another location.

ESTIVATION A state similar to hibernation, but occurring in hot, dry seasons.

EVERGREEN Having some green leaves all the year round.

EVOLUTION Cumulative change over time brought about mainly by natural selection. Organisms with characteristics that not only enhance

survival, but can also be inherited pass them on to their offspring. The genetic makeup of the population changes as these advantageous features spread through the population. See also *Adaptation*.

EXOSKELETON A skeleton situated on the outside of an animal, such as is found in insects and other arthropods. See also *Arthropod*.

EXOTIC In ecology, a term for any nonnative species.

F
FEN A type of wetland, formed when glaciers retreat, that receives its water supply mainly through groundwater seepage. Typically, it does not have standing water in the growing season, and is less nutrient-poor than a bog. See also *Bog*.

FERAL Term applied to an animal, or population of animals, living successfully in the wild but descended from a domestic species or breed.

FJORD A narrow, steep-sided, deep inlet of the sea, once occupied by a glacier.

FOOD CHAIN A food pathway that can be followed from its creation by plants to the apex predators.

FORAGING Activities concerned with seeking and obtaining food.

FORB Any herbaceous (nonwoody) plant other than grass, and especially such a plant growing naturally in grassland.

FRUGIVORE A fruit-eating animal.

FUMAROLE In volcanic regions, a small opening in the ground from which hot gases can escape.

G
GASTROPODS The group of invertebrate animals that includes snails and slugs.

GENUS The first level of traditional biological classification above species. A genus may contain one or more species. For example, lions belong to the genus *Panthera*.

GESTATION Pregnancy. In animals that produce live young, the gestation period is the time between fertilization and birth of the young.

GEYSER A jet of boiling water and steam that rises at intervals from the ground. It is powered by hot rocks heating groundwater.

GROOMING Behaviors that keep body coverings (fur, feathers, etc.) in good condition. In some species individuals may groom each other for social reasons.

H
HABITAT Any area that can support a group or community of living things.

HELICONIA A genus of plants mainly found in the American tropics, often having flower clusters with distinctive red bracts that are pollinated by hummingbirds.

HERBIVORE An animal that eats plants.

HERMAPHRODITE An animal that is both male and female at some point in its life. Species that are both sexes at once are called "simultaneous hermaphrodites;" those that change from one sex to the other are "sequential hermaphrodites."

HIBERNATION A state in which the bodily processes of an animal are drastically slowed down in winter, with the animal becoming completely inactive. The term is mainly applied to "warm-blooded" animals that drastically reduce their heart rate and let their body temperatures fall close to those of their surroundings. See also *Brumation*, *Estivation*.

HIND-GUT DIGESTION A type of digestion found in animals such as horses and elephants, in which tough plant food is fermented in the hind part of the gut, often in an enlarged cecum. See also *Cecum*.

HORNS Paired, permanent structures with a core of bone sheathed by a hard outer layer of keratin, found on the heads of cloven-hooved animals such as antelope and cattle. Rhinoceros horns are not paired or attached to the skull, and they are sited on the nasal bones rather than the top of the head. Consisting only of keratin, there may be one or two depending on species. See also *Antlers*, *Keratin*.

HOTSPOT (1) In ecology, a region or location with a very high biodiversity, especially one that contains many endemic species and is under threat. (2) In geology, hotspots are fixed points that are unusually hot due to molten rock rising from deep within the Earth and are sites of volcanic activity.

HYBRIDIZATION Cross-breeding between different species or strains of organisms.

INDICATOR SPECIES A species whose presence or absence may define an ecoregion or indicate some significant feature, such as the presence of pollution.

INSECTIVORE An animal, especially a land vertebrate, that eats mainly insects.

INTRODUCED SPECIES A species introduced by humans to a particular region and now living successfully in the wild there. See also *Exotic*.

INVERTEBRATE Any animal without a backbone. Of the 30 or so major groups into which animals are classified, vertebrates (backboned animals) form only part of one single group (see *Chordate*): all other animals are invertebrates.

ISLET A small island.

J
JET STREAM High-altitude strong winds that are confined to a relatively narrow band within the atmosphere. Such winds blow in a winding course from west to east in both hemispheres, and their position influences the pattern of weather systems nearer the ground.

K
KARST A type of landscape that develops in regions where the underlying rock, most commonly limestone, is water soluble. Karst landscapes are characterized by deep gorges, underground rivers, and caves.

KERATIN A tough structural protein found in hair, claws, feathers, and horns.

KEYSTONE SPECIES Any species native to a particular ecosystem whose presence or absence has a major impact on the functioning of that ecosystem.

KINGDOM The second highest level in traditional biological classification. Originally there were the animal and plant kingdoms, but later, other kingdoms were introduced to cover fungi and other microorganisms.

KIT Name for the young of various mammals, such as mink and muskrat.